



# UZBEKS

## MERCHANTS OF THE SILK ROAD

AMONG THE ANCESTORS OF TODAY'S UZBEKS were merchants who traded along the Silk Road centuries ago. Arab conquerors in the seventh century ushered in a golden age in which Bukhara became one

### The importance of Islam

The vast majority of Uzbeks are Muslims. Islamic religion and culture have been a major influence in central Asia since the arrival of the Arab conquerors in the seventh century. After the official atheism of the communist era, Islam has enjoyed renewed support, but for many Uzbeks this is more cultural than religious.

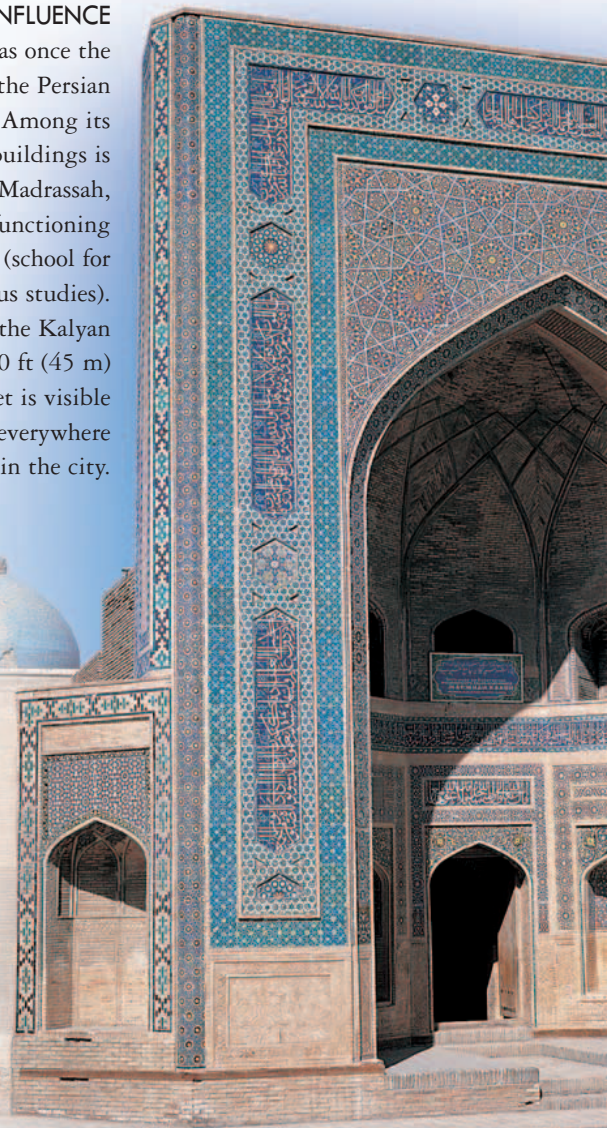
#### MUSLIM PRAYER

An *imam* (prayer leader) and his assistant pray at central mosque in the city of Margilan. Since independence Uzbeks officially enjoy freedom of religion, but mosques and religious leaders are nevertheless closely monitored by the state.



#### ARABIC INFLUENCE

Bukhara was once the capital city of the Persian Empire. Among its magnificent buildings is the Mir-i-Arab Madrassah, still a functioning *madrassah* (school for Islamic religious studies). Nearby is the Kalyan Mosque; its 150 ft (45 m) high minaret is visible from almost everywhere in the city.



#### BEAUTIFUL BREAD

Round Uzbek loaves known as *nan* (as in India) are subject to many traditions. It is considered disrespectful to place bread upside down on the table; and bread is never cut with a knife but torn into pieces and given to those present.



#### CARPET SUPERSTORE

Merchants and traders have plied their wares along the cities of the Silk Road for hundreds of years. Even today Tashkent, the capital of Uzbekistan, is famed for its lively bazaars. This is the carpet department of the main market.

